

Killer INSTINCT

The coach believes that the team's hard work and persistence have given football-lovers of the region a sense of identity

For chief coach Stanley Rosario, the challenge has just begun. Having taken charge of Lajong in July 2009, he believes that his main goal now is to keep the team in the I-League, for which it needs more experienced players.

"Lajong has given the right platform to players from this region and the sense of belonging is very strong," feels the coach, obviously proud of his young wards. Initially, he did face problems as players are a temperamental lot and this team had to be taught the basic tenets of professionalism. They can get very emotional, which has to be controlled. "But other than that they do what I tell them and practice as long as I want

them to," he says.

But what made him take up an unknown unit like Lajong who were first-timers in the I-League? "I knew some of the boys in the team. They all were very hard-working. I believed in them. Also, they have inborn talent and skill which just needs proper guidance," says Rosario, who has seen many years of Indian football. India has

seen many players from the North-east excel, and he was sure that this talented lot will do well. The boys' honesty on the field and their killer instinct as well as determination only added to his confidence.

Rosario's coaching tactics include giving one-on-one counselling to instill discipline and professionalism among the players. They are responding to it easily as they believe this is what they need to walk on the right path and wipe away the image of the errant and indisciplined player from the North-east that seems to be embedded in the psyche of the footballing public.

When the boys from Shillong beat East Bengal 1-0 in the Durand Cup, it was almost a personal victory for the man who was unceremoniously dumped by the same team. "Yes it was a great feeling, almost having proved a point," he says with a smile.

THE TEAM IN ACTION AGAINST MOHUN BAGAN



to leave their home to pursue it as a profession.

But Lajong also faces a problem that many I-League teams in India are yet to overcome—they still do not have a ground of their own. Their practice ground is in a village called Mawkasiang, which is a 30-minutes drive from Shillong. The villagers gave away their land so that the boys' could practice. For the matches, Lajong's home ground is the government-owned Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium.

The club Lajong's best investment is its junior teams. Its under-19 and under-15 batches play in the Shillong League and take part in the AIFF junior tournaments. An academy for the junior squad is on the anvil. It will be a residential one and the under-15 squad will stay with the team for at least another three years. The proposed residential academy should be in place in another year-and-a-half.

The academy does not yet have a playing ground inside the premises but a ground will be made available where the academy wards would practice. The new academy should ideally be able to accommodate around 60 children, Larsing hopes.

Like Lajong in the I-League, Larsing too is a young administrator now in the executive committee of the AIFF. He believes that his seniors in the organisation are appreciative of the fact that finally a team from the North East has made it to the top rung. For the country considered one of the slowest movers in football, this is an important and significant step.

True to the ethos of Lajong, the team is a mix of players from the seven states of the region. Apart from the four foreigners, there are seven Mizo

boys, five from Manipur and one each from Assam and Arunachal Pradesh. The home state, Meghalaya, has 10 players in the team. The quiet and reserved defender, Aibor Khongjee, is the captain of the team. Its goalkeeper Gumpo Rime from Arunachal Pradesh has nearly 14 years of experience. His presence, says assistant coach Thangboi Singto, is a big help for the junior players, who haven't had much exposure yet, to stay focused. Rime may belong to Arunachal, but considers finding this place amongst Meghalaya's "Our Own" is a homecoming of sorts, where he finds himself appreciated and understood.

From the second division to nearing the pinnacle of the domestic game has taken Shillong Lajong a mere two years. Now there is a new breeze of optimism and hope. After all, this team from a state full of hills does have the lungs to climb high. ■